PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #60 · PTSD

“If I care about someone, they will be hurt, or I will lose them.”

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Where it often comes from

Some people come to believe that their love is dangerous. If they care, the other person will be hurt, leave, or be taken. Sometimes loss taught that lesson with terrible force. The lie says your affection is the cause, so the safe life is a life without closeness. Love is not a weapon you are carrying. You can care, with wisdom and with help, without deciding that your heart puts people in harm’s way. A counselor can help you untangle grief from this rule. A counselor can help you work with this at a pace that is safe. You do not have to do it alone, or all at once.

What Scripture teaches

Perfect love casts out fear. There is a kind of fear that has to do with punishment, and it does not belong in love. Jesus loves His friends and tells them to remain in that love. Nothing can separate you from the love of God. The Lord is near the brokenhearted, including when love and loss have gotten tangled. We are called to carry one another’s burdens, which means closeness is part of how God intends care to move. Your love is not a curse on the people you cherish.

> *“There is no fear in love, but perfect love drives out fear, because fear involves punishment. The one who fears has not been perfected in love”* (1 John 4:18).

Also see

> “As the Father has loved Me, so have I loved you. Remain in My love” (John 15:9).

> “For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor principalities, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord” (Romans 8:38–39).

> “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit” (Psalm 34:18).

> “Carry one another’s burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ” (Galatians 6:2).

Common self-statements

- If I love them, something bad will happen to them.
- I should keep my distance for their sake.
- People are safer when I do not care.
- Getting close is selfish.
- I destroy what I love.
- God’s love is for other people, not for someone like me.

Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Deciding that your care will cause future harm.
- Personalization: Making yourself the cause of a loss you could not prevent.
- Overgeneralization: Turning one loss into a rule that love is dangerous.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling afraid of closeness and calling that fear proof.

Challenging questions

- What loss am I treating as proof that my love causes harm?

- Would I tell a grieving friend to stop loving so their people will be safe?
- What is the difference between reasonable care and this fearful rule?
- Who has been close to me and has not been harmed by that closeness?
- What does Scripture say love does with fear?
- What would one ordinary act of care look like this week, without a vow of distance?

Truth summary

> Caring about someone does not put them in danger. I can love, with wisdom, without calling my heart the cause of harm.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Love, By God
- Friendship
- Fear
- Trust
- Sorrow

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Love
- Grief
- Suffering

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from "The Mentally Healthy Christian" (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Listen: Overcoming Depression

Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Love Take Me Over — Steven Curtis Chapman
God's love can take you over without putting the people you love in danger.

Jesus — Chris Tomlin
Jesus stayed near suffering. Love did not make Him a danger to others.

What You Want — Tenth Avenue North
You can follow love without controlling every outcome.

Turn Your Eyes Upon Jesus — Reawaken Hymns
Look at Christ's love, not at the fear that caring will destroy someone.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "If I care about someone, they will be hurt, or I will lose them."

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If I care about someone, they will be hurt, or I will lose them." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What loss am I treating as proof that my love causes harm?
- ☐ Would I tell a grieving friend to stop loving so their people will be safe?
- ☐ What is the difference between reasonable care and this fearful rule?
- ☐ Who has been close to me and has not been harmed by that closeness?
- ☐ What does Scripture say love does with fear?
- ☐ What would one ordinary act of care look like this week, without a vow of distance?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Caring about someone does not put them in danger. I can love, with wisdom, without calling my heart the cause of harm.
- ☐ My love is not a threat.
- ☐ Loss is not proof that caring caused it.
- ☐ I can be close and still be wise.
- ☐ God's love is not something I will ruin by receiving it.
- ☐ Grief and love can exist together.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ 1 John 4:18
  "There is no fear in love, but perfect love drives out fear, because fear involves punishment. The one who fears has not been perfected in love."
- ☐ John 15:9
  "As the Father has loved Me, so have I loved you. Remain in My love."
- ☐ Romans 8:38–39
  "For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor principalities, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord."

A verse I found myself:

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] When loving someone felt dangerous: Each day, write down one moment when closeness felt like it would cause harm. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, 1 John 4:18 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Love does not have to be mixed with this fear. My care is not a curse.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Love, By God" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio or the Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- [ ] Separate love from the loss. Write "I care" and "What I could not prevent" on two lines. Do not make the first line the cause of the second.
- [ ] One ordinary kindness. Do one small caring thing for someone safe, with your counselor's blessing if this belief is very loud.
- [ ] Notice who is all right. After you care, write what actually happened to them that day, not what you feared.
- [ ] Talk with your counselor about where this rule came from, without going into graphic detail.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If I care about someone, they will be hurt, or I will lose them.": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A moment of care that did not cause harm
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If I care about someone, they will be hurt, or I will lose them~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have treated my love as something dangerous. Your love casts out fear. Teach me that caring is not a curse, and walk with me as I risk ordinary closeness again. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.